

4
THE KARACHI CRICKET CULT

I'M NO cricket historian or master strategist, but I know that every cricket-playing nation has its own culture and subculture, which eventually percolates into the game. The basics matter and become part of your cricketing DNA. They structure your approach and ethics towards the game. Want to know where we get our famous Pakistani aggression from? Read on.

Almost all Pakistani cricketers, the great ones at least, began by playing on the streets with tape and tennis balls. We stand out in this regard. In stark contrast, there are hordes of foreign cricketers who have never played anywhere except at a cricket ground. Does streetside cricket make a difference in how Pakistanis play? Yes, it does.

Firstly, it has made our hand–eye coordination sharper. The tape ball is smaller than a cricket ball and it travels faster and swings a lot more. Thus, as a batsman, you have to be more nimble to attack the ball. Secondly, the tape ball is faster through the air and from the ground. It swings a mile if you shave off the tape from one side. Importantly, you can play more daring strokes, especially the big, lofted hits.

The concept is pretty simple. A tennis ball, a good one like a Dunlop, is taped up with a single layer of electric tape. Nitto, a Japanese electric tape widely available in Karachi in a variety of colours, was the preferred choice in my days. If the money was too tight for a Dunlop, we would go for a Winn, maybe a Leopard, but you couldn't dip too low; the ball wouldn't have much bounce otherwise. To make things complicated, we sometimes taped them up in multiple colours, but the preferred shades simulated real cricket: red for day matches, white for night.

The taping is done in different ways to stimulate swing and spin, and one can even put in a hard seam in the middle by applying extra tape. The result is a ball that is faster, lighter, moves more in the air and on the ground, and lasts five or six overs on the burning asphalt of a paved Karachi road. Playing with just a tennis ball wouldn't give the extra pace required to simulate a proper cricket ball. Younger kids, however, start with a tennis ball, because it doesn't hurt as much and is slower.